

**PRUNED IF WE DON'T
&
PRUNED IF WE DO**

TEXT: John 15:1-8 (NKJV) *“I am the true vine, and My Father is the vinedresser. 2 Every branch in Me that does not bear fruit He takes away; and every branch that bears fruit He prunes, that it may bear more fruit. 3 You are already clean because of the word which I have spoken to you. 4 Abide in Me, and I in you. As the branch cannot bear fruit of itself, unless it abides in the vine, neither can you, unless you abide in Me. 5 “I am the vine, you are the branches. He who abides in Me, and I in him, bears much fruit; for without Me you can do nothing. 6 If anyone does not abide in Me, he is cast out as a branch and is withered; and they gather them and throw them into the fire, and they are burned. 7 If you abide in Me, and My words abide in you, you will ask what you desire, and it shall be done for you. 8 By this My Father is*

glorified, that you bear much fruit; so you will be My disciples.”

INTRO: In this passage we are introduced to:

- The vineyard – The Kingdom of God
- The Vinedresser – Father God
- The vine – Jesus
- The branches – All of us

My first public job was working in a peach orchard when I was about 13 years old. It is shocking how many lessons I learned in a peach orchard, that I can practically apply to ministry, even to this very day – 52 years later.

I eventually worked every aspect of the orchard over about a four-year period. I started as a general laborer, picking peaches. By the end of my first day, I knew that I didn't want to make a career out of picking peaches.

I graduated through a series of jobs in my upward trajectory of climbing the ladder of success in the peach orchard:

- I moved to keeping the conveyor belts at the peach shed supplied with peaches that had come from the orchard...
- I worked in the peach shed, grading peaches...
- I worked with a crew picking up peach crates and staking them on the peach trailer, pulled by a guy driving the tractor...
- I became the tractor driver... (At 13-14 years old this was the most coveted job in the orchard)
- I eventually got to drive the Bob truck from the orchard to the market, which was about a 70 - mile round trip... (This was my favorite assignment and at 16 years old I can't believe anyone let me drive a Bob truck across the parking lot, let alone on a highway)

The job I liked the least was pruning! Honestly, I never really understood it, I just tried as best as I could to make it look good under the tree when I was finished!

Pruning sounds painful because it indicates something must be cut away. Pruning is actually more painful than it sounds. However, pruning is absolutely essential to the harvest.

Most of us don't like the thought of pruning. If you can't wait until the next pruning season in your life or ministry that you lead – You may be dismissed! This is not the right conference for you! You are a sick person and need a mental health conference!

Pruning is necessary for two reasons:

- Unfruitfulness...
- Fruitfulness...

UNFRUITFUL BRANCHES

Rest assured, we will be pruned if we do bear fruit and pruned if we don't bear fruit! We might as well throw caution to the wind and do the things necessary to bear fruit!

Listen to the words of Jesus in John 15:2

“Every branch in Me that does not bear fruit He takes away...” What about pruning the unfruitful branches rather than taking them away? The Greek word for ***“takes away”*** is ***“Airo”*** (I'd – row) and can be translated as either ***“lifts up”*** or ***“takes up”***, ***“raises.”***

Grapevines, if left unattended, will grow along the ground. And if left lying on the ground, will send little roots down into the soil. In so doing, if left unattended, they will begin to rely on their own root system for life and sustainability, rather than drawing life from the vine! (Place a pic of a grape branch growing along the ground and the root system of such a branch)

If allowed to remain unattended, such a branch can produce some fruit, but the fruit will eventually become bitter grapes, at best!

So, when a vinedresser comes along, and sees branches lying on the ground, he knows what they need is not to draw their own nutrients from the soil, but to get their nutrients from the vine, because the vine's root system goes deep.

In such a case, what does the vinedresser do? He lifts the branch up off the ground and supports it in the air with a Trestle or lattice work. [\(Place a silent video of this process happening on the screen\)](#) The pruning process here, literally calls for the vinedresser to uproot the branch! What is the Vinedresser attempting to uproot in our lives and ministries?

This sounds painful, correct? You are right, it is painful, but only for a short time, because now the source of the branch will come from a new place, and so will the fruitfulness!

Pruning has been ordered in the Kingdom for all unfruitful branches. Among ministry leaders the necessity of uprooting some systems stem from:

- Putting our trust in people...
- Putting our trust in systems...
- Putting our trust in organizations...
- Putting our trust in the deep pockets of the donors...

At times the Vinedresser will come along and intentionally uproot these things in our lives, for the purpose of making us fruitful! The trestle or lattice that the Vinedresser utilizes, trains the branch to go in an upward direction. (That's the work of the Holy Spirit in our lives – He is leading onward and upward – moveon.org)

When the Vinedresser reroutes the branch, the branch has no choice but to draw all its

sustenance from the vine! What are we trusting in? When we begin to draw our sustenance from the vine instead of from our own deep-rooted systems, the result will be many large clusters of sweet grapes, which to the Vinedresser equals fruitfulness.

Lifting up (Pruning) the grapevines canopy will influence not only the potential yield of the crop, but also the quality of the grapes. This is due to the access of air and sunlight needed for the grapes to ripen fully and for preventing various diseases.

I am believing the Father is going to show up at Empowerment 2024 to see what we have attached ourselves to, that is causing fruitlessness or bitter fruit to be birthed in us!

I am also believing He is going to uproot us and fasten us to something that will lift us in an upward direction. The question then: Are we

going to allow him to hang us on the trestle or lattice of His choosing!

Rest assured, rather than chopping us off and throwing us away – He is in the house to lift us up! He is here to attach us to the lattice or trestle of the Holy Spirit! He is here to start a work in our lives of training us to grow in the right direction.

FRUITFUL BRANCHES

Some of us are sitting here tonight saying, “*Whew, I am getting off Scott free – I am producing Kingdom fruit!*” Not so quick! Matthew 15:1-2 (NKJV) “***I am the true vine, and My Father is the vinedresser. 2 Every branch in Me that does not bear fruit He takes away; and every branch that bears fruit He prunes, that it may bear more fruit.***”

(Pick up pruning shears)

Who is subject to pruning?

- Unfruitful branches...
- Fruitful branches...

Who is authorized to do the pruning? The Husbandman and/or those He has specifically trained and authorized to do so! Do you know, that with all the modern agricultural machinery that has been developed – No one has been able to automate the pruning of a vineyard! To this very day, it is all done by hand!

Grapevines grow through pruning. If all the energy goes into the leaves and unproductive runners, then it will take away from the size and quality of the fruit.

Some folks are at this conference who are at the top of their game. They are walking in the most fruitful season of their lives. Yet, they are experiencing the pain of pruning, and this makes no sense to us.

Even though the vines are yielding their strength, all vines must be periodically pruned so that the size and quality of fruit can be increased exponentially.

When I worked in the peach orchard, the grower knew that everything was reliant on the trees being pruned at exactly the right time. The grower knew the harvest was going to be affected proportionately with the pruning, or lack of it.

When I look back on my experience in the peach orchard, the grower wasn't trying to punish the trees with pruning. If the trees could talk, they would tell you of the pain of that momentary experience, but when harvesttime rolled around, they would thank the grower and his staff for the pruning. [\(Play silent video of our Arizona Ash trees being pruned\)](#)

Are you ready for this?

Pruning ordered by the Husbandman is never punitive in nature – It is always future focused!

Ladies and gentlemen, the Father's pruning tool is His Word! He doesn't show up with something that looks like this pruning tool that I hold in my hand He shows up with His Word!
(Trade pruning shears for a paper Bible)

When the Father shows up with pruning shears in hand – He doesn't have punishment or discipline in mind, He shows up focused on the future! All pruning by the Vinedresser is future focused! ***“Who for the joy set before Him...”***

Some of us in this room today:

- Are in survival mode...
- Are under stress...
- Have been damaged in some way...

Some of you made up your mind before you came to this conference, to go a direction that you felt would help you recover. But the

Vinedresser is in the room today with his pruning shears to let you know; that's not the direction you need to be going in; that's not the right decision.

He is here to lift you up and prune away the areas that are hindering your destiny and your purpose. When He prunes us He is going to attach us to that which will get us headed in the direction of the harvest!

Everything the Vinedresser does, including the pruning process, is done with our future in mind.

CONCLUSION:

The most important instructions given in this verse is found in John 15:7-8 ***“If you abide in Me, and My words abide in you, you will ask what you desire, and it shall be done for you. 8 By this My Father is glorified, that you bear much fruit; so you will be My disciples.”***